

History of English

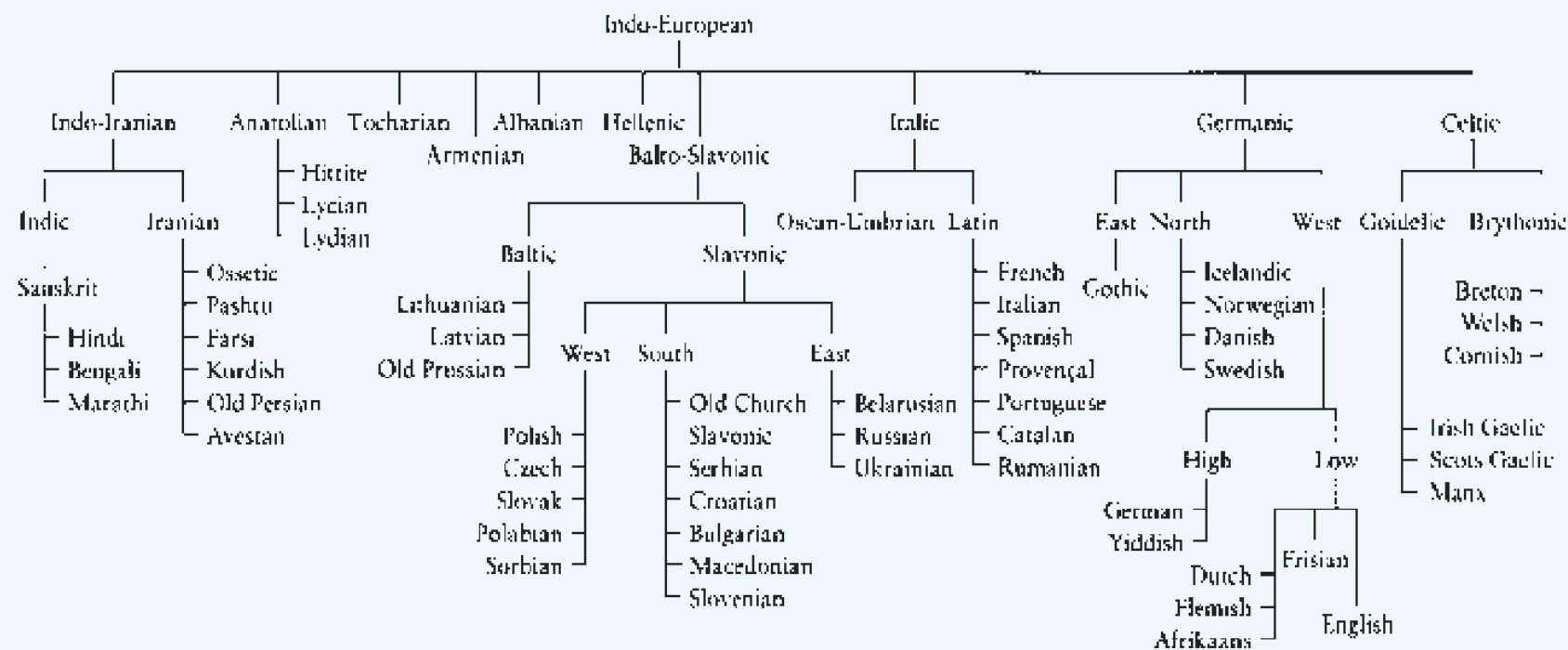
Introduction to linguistics — **Course Website** — 19 January 2026

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Overview

The Indo-European language family

Fig. 2.3



The Indo-European language family (adapted from Fennell 2001:22)

Morphosyntactic types of languages

- **synthetic**: many inflections, many forms per lexeme, free word order
 - **inflecting**: (or fusional) one morpheme usually expresses a bundle of grammatical information (e.g. Latin, **Old English**)
 - **agglutinative**: one morpheme usually expresses one specific piece of grammatical information (e.g. Hungarian)
- **analytic**: few inflections, few forms per lexeme, many function words and periphrastic constructions, relatively rigid word order (e.g. **Modern English**)
 - **isolating**: no inflections, one form per lexeme (e.g. Mandarin Chinese)

Periods of English

| Fig. 2.1

period	historical landmarks	key linguistic features
Pre-English (before c450 AD)	Celts Romans (43–410)	➤ Celtic language spoken ➤ some Celtic traces, esp. in place names ➤ Latin becomes the official language ➤ a few Latin traces from this period through Celtic transmission
Old English (c450–c1150)	Germanic tribes arrive (Angles, Saxons, Jutes and Frisians) from the middle of the fifth century	➤ mostly Germanic word-stock ➤ fully inflected ➤ inflections begin to be levelled
Middle English (c1150–c1500)	Norman Conquest in 1066	➤ enormous influx of French vocabulary ➤ levelled inflections ➤ Great Vowel Shift starts
Early Modern English (c1500–c1700)	introduction of printing into England by William Caxton in 1476 spread of English around the world starts (colonisation)	➤ Great Vowel Shift ➤ standardisation and regularisation ➤ large-scale borrowing from Latin, Greek, French and other European languages
Modern English (c1700–present) Present Day English (c1900–present)	English as a global language	➤ almost no inflections ➤ borrowing from many languages world-wide

The periods of the English language

Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 13

Old English

External history

- **from A.D. 410** (traditional date according to Bede's *Historia Ecclesiastica Gentis Anglorum*, 449): Angles, Saxons and Jutes (and probably some Frisians), speaking varieties of West Germanic languages, conquer the main British Isle ("**Germanic Conquest**")
- **c. 700**: earliest written documents in Old English
- from **6th century: Christianization**
 - Irish missionaries (c. 563; St. Columba to Iona)
 - missionaries from Rome (c. 597; St. Augustine to Canterbury)
- from **8th century** onwards: **Viking raids and Danish settlement**
 - 793: sacking of Monastery of Lindisfarne
 - 878: establishment of the *Danelaw*

Old English dialects

Fig. 2.2 |

The origins and distribution of the main dialects of Old English (Crystal 2002:174)



Viking invasions



Kohnen (2014)

The Futhorc alphabet

Fig. 2.4 |

*The futhorc runic
alphabet*
(Moessner 2003:4)



Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 18

Old English declensions

Fig. 2.5

Old English masc. a-stem *stān* 'stone', neut. a-stem *scip* 'ship' and fem. o-stem *giefu* 'gift'

	Singular	Plural	Singular	Plural	Singular	Plural
Nominative	<i>stān</i>	<i>stān -as</i>	<i>scip</i>	<i>scip -u</i>	<i>gief -u</i>	<i>gief -a</i>
Genitive	<i>stān -es</i>	<i>stān -a</i>	<i>scip -es</i>	<i>scip -a</i>	<i>gief -e</i>	<i>gief -a</i>
Dative	<i>stān -e</i>	<i>stān -um</i>	<i>scip -e</i>	<i>scip -um</i>	<i>gief -e</i>	<i>gief -um</i>
Accusative	<i>stān</i>	<i>stān -as</i>	<i>scip</i>	<i>scip -u</i>	<i>gief -e</i>	<i>gief -a</i>

Examples illustrating selected Old English nominal declensions

Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 18

Linguistic characteristics

- Germanic **vocabulary** (West Germanic “Erbwortschatz”) with some Latin (e.g. *wine, cheese, street*) and Old Norse (e.g. *take, die, sky*) loanwords
- **word order** relatively free
- **inflecting/synthetic** language; e.g. adjectives and nouns inflect for 4 cases, 2 numbers, 3 grammatical genders
- **pronunciation**: strong differences to PDE

Sound example:



i-mutation (*i*-Umlaut) (c. 500/600)

- between Germanic and Old English; conditioned sound change
- Germanic back vowels got fronted (or palatalized), front vowels got raised by /i/ or /j/ in the following syllable
- remnants in PDE: *mouse* – *mice*, *foot* – *feet*, *louse* – *lice* etc.

Germanic Erbwortschatz

Elements that survived from OE are basic elements of the vocabulary and are very frequent: pronouns, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs etc.

Fundamental concepts:

- oe. *mann* 'man'
- oe. *wīf* 'wife'
- oe. *cīld* 'child'
- oe. *hūs* 'house'
- oe. *drincan* 'drink'
- oe. *libban* 'live'

Latin influence

- **continental** borrowings: *street, wine, kitchen, mile, butter, cheese*
- borrowings after **settlement of Britain** (after 450): *port, mount, -chester*
- borrowings during **Christianization**: *martyr, clerk, creed, nun,, verse*
- later borrowings: part. during **Renaissance**

Old Norse influence

- Viking raids ('Danelaw')
- genetic resemblance between Old Norse and Old English
- strong influence on basic vocabulary:
 - function words: *they, them, their, though*
 - verbs: *to call, to die, to take, to raise*
 - nouns: *law, husband, egg, birth*
 - adjectives: *awkward, ill, weak*

Consequence: English drifts apart from West Germanic languages, e.g. German

Middle English

External history

- 1066: **Norman Conquest** (William the Conqueror; Battle of Hastings)
- for more than three centuries (mid–11th to mid–14th cent.), England was trilingual (**Triglossia**): (Anglo-)French and Latin as ‘high variety’ and English as ‘low variety’
- from mid-14th century: English slowly re-established in various domains (1349 English as language of education, 1362 opening of Parliament, literary language) → English re-introduced as **high variety**

Language contact

Traces of linguistic **contact situations** can be found.

- with **Celtic**: little influence, mostly place names: *London, Dover, Kent*
- with **Latin**: in trade, place names and Christianisation: *priest, monk, school*
- with **French**: in government, art, justice, etc.: *administration, government*

French influence

Superstrate influence: situation in which the language of a group of speakers in a socially or politically superior position influences that of the speakers in an inferior position ([Herbst 2010, 316](#)).

Examples

leisure/arts: *art, beauty, chess, colour, dance, falcon, image, leisure, literature, melody, music, painting, pen, poet, preface, prose, recreation, rhyme, romance, sculpture, story, tragedy, volume*

science: *anatomy, calendar, gender, geometry, grammar, logic, medicine, metal, noun, pain, physician, poison, square, study*

general nouns: *action, adventure, age, air, city, comfort, courage, debt, envy, error, face, flower, hour, joy, labour, marriage, mountain, number, opinion, order, people, person, poverty, power, river, sign, unity, vision*

general adjectives: *active, blue, calm, certain, clear, cruel, curious, eager, easy, final, foreign, gentle, honest, horrible, large, natural, nice, perfect, poor, real, rude, safe, second, simple, single, special, sure*

general verbs: *advise, allow, carry, change, close, continue, cry, enjoy, enter, inform, join, marry, move, obey, pass, prefer, prove, quit, receive, refuse, remember, satisfy, save, serve, suppose, trip*

Consequence: large, mixed vocabulary

- many **synonyms** —> fine nuances in meaning: *liberty* – *freedom*, *short* – *brief*
- **hard words** ('inkhorn' terms): *hippopotamus*
- weak relation between **orthography** and pronunciation
- **consociation** vs. **dissociation**: ger.: *Mund* – *mündlich*, en.: *mouth* – *oral*

Consociation and dissociation

Table 1: Consociation and dissociation

CONSOCIATION		DISSOCIATION	
<i>Mund</i>	<i>mündlich</i>	<i>mouth</i>	<i>oral</i>
<i>Heiliger</i>	<i>heilig</i>	<i>saint</i>	<i>holy</i>
<i>Fuß</i>	<i>Fußgänger</i>	<i>foot</i>	<i>pedestrian</i>
<i>Wort</i>	<i>wörtlich</i>	<i>word</i>	<i>verbal</i>
<i>Buch</i>	<i>Buchstabe</i>	<i>book</i>	<i>letter</i>

The Canterbury Tales



Fig. 2.6

The Canterbury Tales

Linguistic characteristics

- transition from a synthetic to a **more analytic** language (early Middle English) due to breakdown of inflection caused by weakening of final syllables ('Entsilbenabschwächung': /a/, /u/, /o/ > /ə/ > Ø)
- loss of grammatical **gender** at around 1200 (replaced by natural gender; article *the*)
- less flexibility in **word order**
- '**dialect age**': no generally accepted standard
- huge number of **borrowings** in the field of war/military, administration/law, religion/church, fashion, social life etc. (+ influence on word formation and stress patterns) → end of Middle English: mixed Germanic/Romance vocabulary
- **pronunciation**: see sound sample [on YouTube](#)
- **triglossia**: from mid-11th to mid-14th century
 - high varieties
 - 1→ Latin: church, learning, documents
 - 2→ French: upper classes, feudal aristocracy
 - low variety:
 - 3→ English: peasants, lower clergy, most people in the city

Exercise: spot the loanwords

Read the following newspaper article and spot the loanwords.

Romance/Latin — Greek — other/uncertain

Scottish whale watchers' photos used to gain insights into animals' habits.

Images taken by public reveal insights into threatened minke whales, including finding the most attention-seeking whale

Snowy is the oldest known minke whale in Europe, while Knobble appears to adore attention – or, at least, the whale has been spotted more than 60 times since 2002, mostly close to the Isle of Mull. Photographic records of minke whales submitted by members of the public are being published in a digital catalogue, providing insights about the threatened species. The research, collated by the Hebridean Whale and Dolphin Trust, reveals that more than 300 individual minke whales have been identified in the Hebrides since 1990. A third (33%) have been seen more than once. “Photographs are a powerful tool for strengthening our understanding of whale movements and the threats they face – providing vital evidence for effective conservation,” said Dr Lauren Hartny-Mills, science and conservation manager for the Hebridean Whale and Dolphin Trust. [...]

The Guardian, 26 October 2023

Solution

Scottish whale watchers' photos used to gain insights into animals' habits.

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Early Modern English

External history

- 1476: William Caxton introduces **printing press** to England
- **Renaissance and Humanism** 'new cultural climate': rediscovery of classical authors and literature
- 1534: **Reformation**
- growing **literacy**

Linguistic characteristics

- **Great Vowel Shift** (from c. 1400/1500) marks the end of Middle English: raising and diphthongization of Middle English long vowels and diphthongs —> increasing discrepancy between phonemes and graphemes
- **weakening/loss of inflections** further continues
- **word order** becomes fixed: SVO
- development of London dialect into a **new standard**
- emergence of **standardized orthography**
- learned **loanwords** from Latin and Greek ('hard words') —> further mixing of vocabulary

Borrowings

From Latin and Greek

anonymous, appropriate, atmosphere, catastrophe, chaos, crisis, criterion, emphasis, encyclopedia, enthusiasm, exact, exaggerate, excursion, exist, expensive, explain, habitual, immaturity, impersonal, lexicon, lunar, monopoly, necessitate, obstruction, parasite, parenthesis, pathetic, pneumonia, relaxation, relevant, scheme, soda, species, system, tactics, temperature, thermometer, transcribe, utopian, vacuum, virus

From or via French

alloy, anatomy, bayonet, bigot, bizarre, chocolate, colonel, comrade, detail, entrance, equip, explore, grotesque, invite, moustache, muscle, naturalise, passport, pioneer, progress, shock, ticket, tomato, vase, vogue, volunteer

From or via Italian

balcony, ballot, carnival, concerto, design, giraffe, grotto, lottery, macaroni, opera, piazza, rocket, solo, sonata, soprano, stanza, trill, violin, volcano

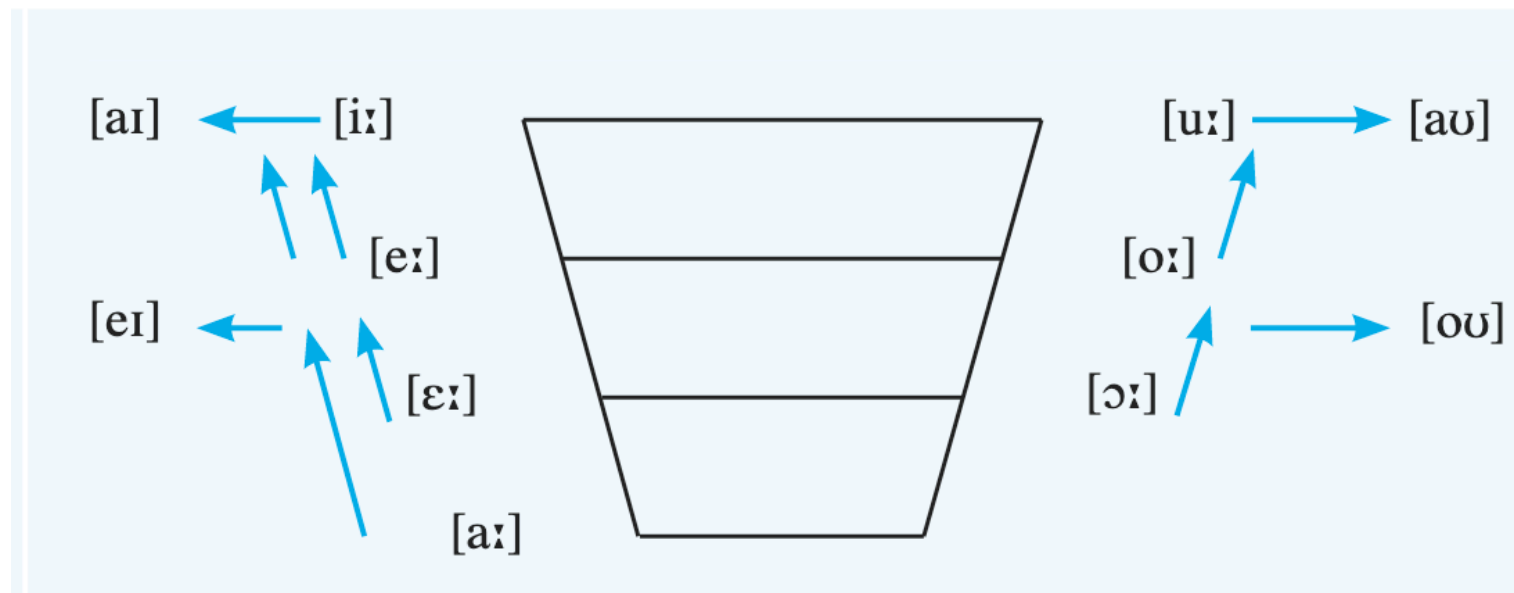
From or via Spanish and Portuguese

alligator, anchovy, apricot, armada, banana, barricade, cannibal, canoe, cockroach, corral, desperado, embargo, guitar, hurricane, maize, mosquito, negro, potato, port (wine), sombrero, tank, tobacco

From other languages

Algonquian: *raccoon, skunk*; Arabian: *harem*; Dutch: *keelhaul, knapsack, landscape, yacht*; Hindi: *guru*; Irish Gaelic: *trousers*; Malay: *bamboo, ketchup*; Norwegian: *troll*; Russian: *rouble*; Persian: *bazaar, caravan, turban*; Tamil: *curry*; Turkish: *coffee, kiosk, yogurt*; Welsh: *flannel*

The Great Vowel Shift



Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 28

- sound change that affects all Middle English long vowels, which are either raised or diphthongized
- leads to the discrepancy between PDE orthography and pronunciation (English spelling had widely been fixed by the time the GVS set in)

Present-Day English

External history

- new **media** (telephone, TV, internet etc.)
- after WWI and WWII: increasing importance of **American English**
- English as a world language and a **lingua franca**
- increasing importance of **Postcolonial Englishes** (e.g. Indian English)

Example: Bible translations

Matthew XXI: 10–17
Jesus at the Temple

Old English (West Saxon Gospels, 10th century)	Middle English (Wycliffe 1389)	Early Modern English (Tyndale 1526)	Modern English (New International Version)
10 Ða he ferde to Ierusalem, ða wearþ eall seo burh-warū onstýred, and cwædon, Hwæt is ðes?	10 And when he had entrid in to Jerusalem, al the cite was stirid, seyinge, Who is this?	10 And when he was come in to Jerusalem, all the cite was moved, sayinge, Who ys this?	10 When Jesus entered Jerusalem, the whole city was stirred and asked, "Who is this?"
11 Ða cwæþ ðæt folc, Ðis ys Hælend, witega, of Nazareth on Galilea.	11 Treuly the peplis seiden, This is Jhesus, the prophete, of Nazareth of Galilee.	11 And the peolpe sayde, Thys ys Jesus, the prophet, off Nazareth a cite of Galile.	11 The crowds answered, "This is Jesus, the prophet from Nazareth in Galilee."
12 Ða se Hælend into ðam temple eode, he adraf ut ealle ða ðe ceapodon innan ðam temple; and ðara mynetera sceamelas, and hyra setlu, ðara ðe culfran sealdon, he tobræc.	12 And Jhesus entride in to the temple of God, and kest out of the temple alle sellynge and byinge; and he turnyde vpsadoun the bordis of chaungeris, and the chaiers of men sellynge culueris.	12 And Jesus went in to the temple of God, and caste out all them that bought and solde in the temple; and overthrew the tables of the mony chaungers, and the seates of them that solde doves.	12 Jesus entered the temple courts and drove out all who were buying and selling there. He overturned the tables of the money changers and the benches of those selling doves.
13 And cwæþ to him, Hyt ys awriten, Min hus ys gebed-hus; witodlice ge worthon ðæt to þeofa cote.	13 And he seith to hem, It is writen, My hous shal be clepid an hous of preiere; forsothe ȝe han made it a denne of thefes.	13 And saide to them, It is written, Mine housse shalbe called the housse off prayer; butt ye have made it a denn of theves.	13 It is written," he said to them, "'My house will be called a house of prayer,' but you are making it 'a den of robbers.
14 Ða eodon to him ða blindan and ða healtan, and he hi gehælde.	14 And blynde and crokid camen niȝ to hym in the temple, and he helide hem.	14 And the blinde and the halt cam to hym in the temple, and he healed them.	14 The blind and the lame came to him at the temple, and he healed them.
15 Witodlice ða ðara sacerda ealdras and ða boceras gesawon ða wundru ðe se Hælend worthie, and gehyrdon hu ða cild clypodon on ðam temple, and cwædon, Sy Dauides sunu hal, ða wæron hig yrræ.	15 Forsothe the princis of prestis and scribis, seeynge the marueilouse thingis that he dide, and children cryinge in the temple, and seynge, Osanna to the sone of Dauith, dedeyneden,	15 When the chefe prestes and scribes sawe the marveylls thatt he dyd, and the chyl dren cryinge in the temple, and sayinge, Hosianna to the sonne of David, they desdayned,	15 But when the chief priests and the teachers of the law saw the wonderful things he did and the children shouting in the temple courts, "Hosanna to the Son of David," they were indignant.
16 And cwædon, Gehyrst ðu hwæt ðas cwæðað? Ða cwæþ he, Witodlice; ne ræddon ge næfre, Ðu fulfremdest lof, of cilda, and of sucendra muþe?	16 And seiden to hym, Heerist thou what these seyen? Sothely Jhesus seith to hem, ȝhe; wher ȝe han nat rad, For of the mouth of children and of soukyngne mylk, thou hast made parfite heryinge?	16 And sayde vnto hym, Hearest thou what these saye? Jesus sayde vnto them, Have ye never redde, Off the mouth off babes and suckelinges, thou haste ordeyned prayse?	"Do you hear what these children are saying?" they asked him. "Yes," replied Jesus, "have you never read," "From the lips of children and infants you, Lord, have called forth your praise'?"

(Bosworth, Joseph, ed. 1888. *The Gothic and Anglo-Saxon Gospels in Parallel Columns with the Versions of Wycliffe and Tyndale*. London: Reeves & Turner.)

Parallel illustrations of Matthew XXI: 10–17, Jesus at the Temple

Modern English Inflections

| Fig. 2.12

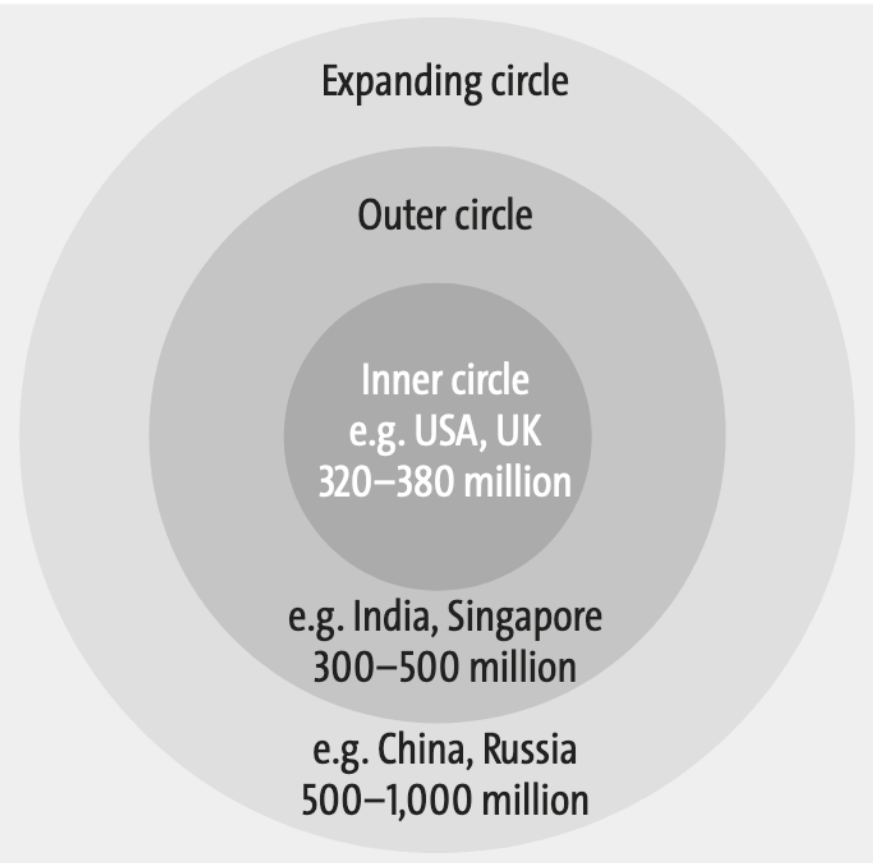
the plural -s	<i>hand ~ hands, cat ~ cats, bus ~ buses</i>
the possessive -'s	<i>lady ~ lady's, Peter ~ Peter's, George ~ George's</i>
3rd person singular present indicative -s	<i>they bring ~ she brings, they drop ~ he drops, we fish ~ she fishes</i>
preterite -ed	<i>play ~ played, work ~ worked, head ~ headed</i>
past participle -ed	<i>play ~ played, work ~ worked, head ~ headed</i>
the -ing-form	<i>read ~ reading</i>
comparative -er	<i>small ~ smaller, big ~ bigger</i>
superlative -est	<i>small ~ smallest, big ~ biggest</i>

Modern English inflections

Bieswanger and Becker (2021): 29

English around the world

The three circles of English (after Kachru, from Crystal 2003:61)



Quiz: History of English



Intro252_history

Created by

Quirin Würschinger

11 questions

[Play now](#)

References

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